Boundless worlds.

They are those worlds that the young Marcel rediscovers, bewildered, every morning, in the first pages of *Remembrance of Things Past*, in the vertigo of the moment when consciousness emerges like a bubble from unfathomable depths.[117] That world of which vast territories are then revealed to him when the taste of the madeleine brings back to him the flavor of Combray. A vast world, a map of which Proust slowly unfolds during the course of the three thousand pages of his great novel. A novel, it should be noted, that is not a narrative of events in the world but an account of what's inside the memory of a single person. From the fragrance of the madeleine at the beginning, to the last word—"time"—of its final part, "Time Regained," the book is nothing but a disordered, detailed meandering among the synapses of Marcel's brain.

Proust finds a limitless space and an incredible throng of details, fragrances, considerations, sensations, reflections, re-elaborations, colors, objects, names, looks, emotions . . . all within the folds of the brain between the ears of Marcel. This is the flow of time familiar from our experience: it is inside there that it nestles, inside of us, in the utterly crucial presence of traces of the past in our neurons.

Proust could not be more explicit on this matter, writing in the first book: "Reality is formed only by memory."[118] And memory, in its turn, is a collection of traces, an indirect product of the disordering of the world, of that small equation written earlier, $\Delta S \geq 0$, the one that tells us the state of the world was in a "particular" configuration in the past and therefore has left (and leaves) traces. "Particular," that is, perhaps only in relation to rare subsystems—ourselves included.

We are stories, contained within the twenty complicated centimeters behind our eyes, lines drawn by traces left by the (re)mingling together of things in the world, and oriented toward predicting events in the future, toward the direction of increasing entropy, in a rather particular corner of this immense, chaotic universe.

This space—memory—combined with our continuous process of anticipation, is the source of our sensing time as time, and ourselves as ourselves.[119] Think about it: our introspection is easily capable of imagining itself without there being space or matter, but can it imagine itself not existing in time?[120]

It is with respect to that physical system to which we belong—due to the peculiar way in which it interacts with the rest of the world, thanks to the fact that it allows traces and because we, as physical entities, consist of memory